



Week 3 – Tutor 2

From Draft to Refined Power BI Dashboard

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Developed with generative AI assistance from ChatGPT (OpenAI).

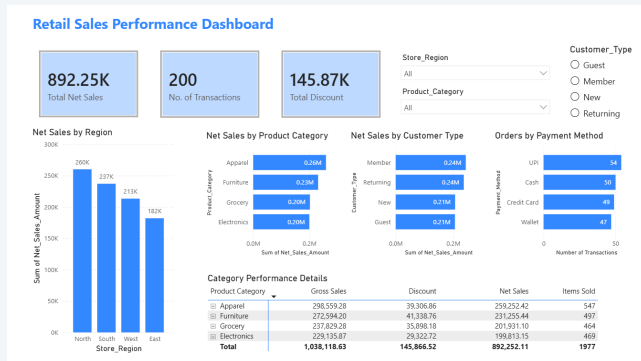
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Start from the Analytical Need

A Working Dashboard Is Not a Finished Dashboard

A dashboard can be technically correct and still require unnecessary reading effort.



It already works

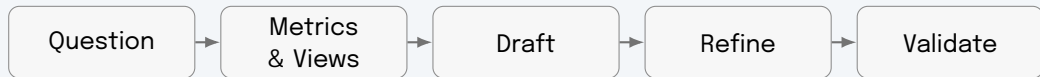
- KPIs are visible.
- Comparisons are available.
- Filters work.
- Details are accessible.

Now ask

- What is easy to read?
- What still competes for attention?

The Builder Flow for This Tutor

Use one workflow from the analytical need to the final design.



Question

What does the reader need to know?

Metrics & Views

What evidence and comparisons answer the question? By How?

Draft

Does the graph/ report work technically?

Refine

Does it communicate clearly and efficiently?

Validate

Did the changes actually make reading easier?



Round 1 – Frame the Task

Work in groups. Do not edit Power BI yet.

Prompt	Your answer
Reader	Who will use this dashboard?
Main question	What do they need to know?
Metrics	Which numbers provide evidence?
Required views	Which comparisons or details are necessary?
First thing to see	What deserves attention first?

Activity

Output: one clear question, three to five key metrics, and the required views.

Time: 5–8 minutes.

From Question to Metrics and Views

Choose only the evidence needed to answer the question.

Need	Metric / Field	Possible view
Overall performance	Net Sales, Transactions, Discount	KPI cards
Regional comparison	Net Sales by Region	Bar / column chart
Product comparison	Net Sales by Product Category	Bar chart
Customer comparison	Net Sales by Customer Type	Bar chart
Payment behaviour	Transactions by Payment Method	Bar chart
Exact details	Sales, Discount, Items Sold	Table / matrix

A visual earns its place when it answers the question or supports a necessary comparison.

Draft First, Refine Second

A draft is not bad. It is simply unfinished.

A useful draft checks

- correct fields,
- correct aggregation,
- suitable basic chart type,
- usable filters,
- readable values.

A refined design checks

- clear meaning,
- reduced clutter,
- intentional attention,
- clear grouping,
- consistent presentation.

The question changes

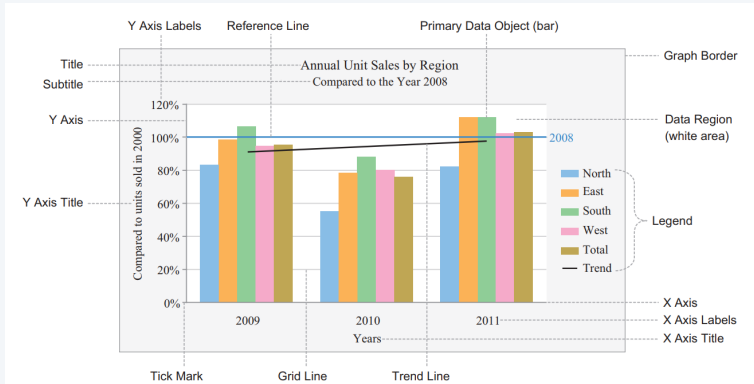
Draft: *Does it work?*

Refine: *Does it communicate well?*

Refine One Graph

A Graph Is Made of Components

A graph is not one object. Each component can support the data, compete with it, or add context.



Audit question for each component: **Remove, Soften, Keep, or Enhance?**



Audit Before You Edit

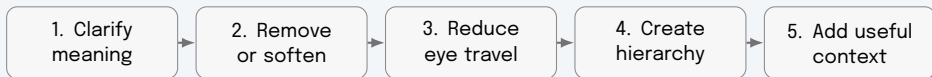
Inspect the current graph before opening the Format pane. For each component, decide whether it should be **removed, softened, kept, or enhanced**.

Component	Typical decision	Question
Title	Keep / improve	Does it clearly state what the reader needs to know?
Axes and scale	Keep / adjust	Is the scale clear and non-distorting? Should bars start at zero?
Gridlines & ticks	Soften / remove	Do they help estimate and compare values, or add clutter?
Data labels	Keep / adjust	Are exact values important for this task?
Legend	Keep / reposition	Is it necessary, and can labels be placed closer to the data?
Color/emphasis	Keep / enhance	Are colors distinct, consistent, and focused on what matters?
Reference/trend lines	Add when useful	Would a target, threshold, benchmark, or trend help interpretation?
Annotations	Add when useful	Is there an important value or pattern that needs a short explanation?
Border/background	Remove / soften	Does it support grouping, or compete with the data?

Remove Soften Keep Enhance

The Five Refinement Passes

Use the passes in order. Each one answers a different reading problem.



Rule

Do not change a setting because Power BI offers it. Change it because it helps the reader.



Pass 1: Clarify What the Graph Shows

Question: Can the reader understand the graph without decoding field names?

Focus first

1. Make the title more informative.
2. Replace technical field names.
3. Sort bars to support comparison.

Lower priority

- standardise display units,
- adjust data labels,
- soften gridlines.

Example

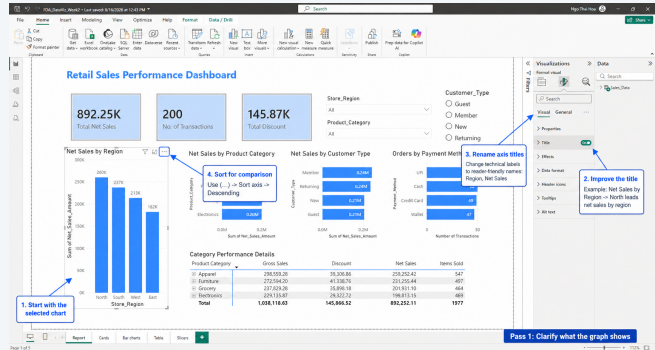
From: Sum of Net_Sales_Amount by Store_Region

To: **North leads net sales by region**

Pass 1 in Power BI: Clarify the Graph

Change

1. Title
Net Sales by Region →
North leads net sales by region
2. Axis labels
Store_Region → **Region**
Sum of Net_Sales_Amount
→ **Net Sales**
3. Sort
North → South → West → East





Pass 2: Remove or Soften Clutter

Question: Which components compete with the data without helping enough?

Focus first

1. Remove redundant axis titles.
2. Soften or remove gridlines.
3. Remove borders, shadows, or strong backgrounds.

Lower priority

- reduce repeated labels,
- simplify unnecessary visual effects,
- keep only context that supports comparison.

Example

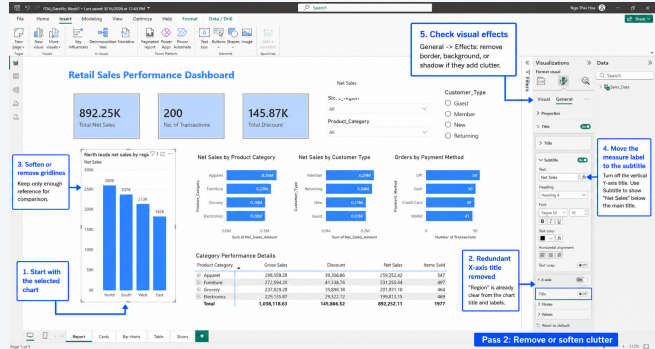
From: a chart with technical axis titles, visible borders, and strong gridlines

To: a cleaner chart where the bars are the main focus

Pass 2 in Power BI: Remove or Soften

Change

1. Axis titles
Turn off if already clear from the chart title or labels.
2. Gridlines
Reduce contrast, reduce weight, or turn off.
3. Border and background
General → Effects
soften or remove border, background, and shadow.





Pass 3 – Reduce Eye Travel

Question: Can the reader decode the graph without looking back and forth?

Inspect

- labels far from data,
- legend far from marks,
- poor sort order,
- hard-to-scan category names,
- unnecessary axis decoding.

Power BI

- Turn on useful **Data labels**.
- Reposition or remove a redundant **Legend**.
- Sort bars by the metric for comparison tasks.
- Resize the visual so labels have enough space.
- Prefer horizontal bars when category labels are long.

Bring related information closer together
so the reader spends less effort decoding the graph.



Pass 4 – Create Visual Hierarchy

Question: What should the reader notice first, second, and later?

Focus first

- place important information prominently,
- give key visuals enough size,
- make important values visually stronger,
- keep supporting information quieter.

Useful hierarchy cues

- position and size,
- contrast and font weight,
- whitespace,
- selective color.

Power BI

- Resize and reposition visuals on the canvas.
- Keep title, value, and label sizes consistent with their importance.
- Make KPI values stronger than supporting labels.
- Use **Data colors / Columns / Bars** only when something deserves emphasis.
- Soften backgrounds, borders, and other supporting elements.

Pass 5 – Add Only Useful Context

Question: What does the reader need to interpret the value correctly?

Add context when it changes interpretation

- time period,
- benchmark or target,
- meaningful reference line,
- short annotation,
- source or update note.

Power BI

- Use a subtitle or small text box for necessary context.
- Add a reference / constant line when a real benchmark exists.
- Annotate only an important value, event, or pattern.
- Keep context visually quieter than the data.



Round 2 – Refine One Graph

Choose one graph from your dashboard. Apply the five passes.

Pass	Your action
Clarify meaning	Improve title, labels, units, and sorting.
Remove / soften	Reduce elements that compete with the data.
Reduce eye travel	Improve labels, legend, spacing, and scan path.
Create hierarchy	Decide what, if anything, should stand out.
Add useful context	Add only context that improves interpretation.

Activity

Save a before screenshot and an after screenshot. Record the three most important changes and why you made them. Time: 15–20 minutes.



Refine the Dashboard Page



Clear Graphs Do Not Automatically Make a Clear Dashboard

Graph-level refinement asks:

Is each visual clear?

Dashboard-level refinement asks:

Do the visuals work together?

Shift the unit of design

At page level, the problem becomes grouping, hierarchy, reading order, and consistency.

Group, Prioritize, Sequence, and Stay Consistent



Use four page-level checks.

Check	Question	Power BI actions
Group	What belongs together?	Move related visuals closer; use whitespace or subtle section headings.
Prioritize	What matters most?	Use position, size, contrast, and card treatment intentionally.
Sequence	Where should the eye go next?	Arrange overview → comparison → detail.
Consistency	Does the page feel like one system?	Standardise fonts, units, colors, spacing, titles, and slicers.



Round 3 – Refine the Dashboard Page

Now refine the page as one reading experience.

1. Group related visuals using spacing and alignment.
2. Prioritize the first thing the reader should see.
3. Arrange a clear path: overview → comparison → detail.
4. Standardise titles, units, colors, card style, and slicer style.
5. Remove or soften page-level clutter.

Round 3 in Power BI – Align the Page

Use Power BI tools to make related visuals line up and use consistent spacing.

View → Gridlines + Snap to grid → Select visuals → Align / Distribute

1. Turn on alignment support

On the top ribbon:

View → Gridlines

View → Snap to grid

Use the grid while moving or resizing visuals so their edges and spacing are easier to match.

2. Align several visuals

Hold **Ctrl** and click the visuals.

Format → Align / Distribute

For example: **Align top** or **Distribute horizontally**.



Validate the Refinement

Draft vs Refined – What Actually Improved?

A redesign is successful when it improves reading, not simply appearance.

Draft

?

Insert your original dashboard screenshot.

Refined

?

Insert your improved dashboard screenshot.

Validation question

What became clearer, faster, or less effortful after the refinement?

Explain Three Design Decisions

Each decision must connect a Power BI action to a reader benefit.

Change		Principle	Reader benefit
Removed axis titles	repeated	Reduce clutter	The chart is cleaner without losing meaning.
Standardised units to K		Consistency	Values are easier to compare across visuals.
Softened background	card	Visual hierarchy	KPIs stay visible without dominating the page.

We changed _____ because it helps the reader _____.



Thank you for your attention!

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